chance to redeem Pakistan. I had worked hard. It all paid off when we clinched the championship.

In the final, too, I was an innings builder, not a butcher of the opposition's attack. I didn't score a boundary till I was at 17 from 19 balls. That's when I took Muralitharan out for a six and a four, consecutively, and slowed down again. I turned on the heat again in the 18th over. I wanted the crown for Pakistan, especially because of what had happened back home, just a few months earlier, in Lahore. But I was in no rush to get it.

There itself I was experiencing a metamorphosis at a personal level. I wanted to win and win more.

Younis Khan would retire from T20 internationals that day. He would dedicate our victory to the memory of Bob Woolmer. He would implore the world to visit Pakistan to play cricket. That day, at Lord's, we were kings. And we deserved the crown more than anyone else.

Then, of course, came scandal – typical of Pakistan. The whitewash in the Australia tour. Yousuf and Younis were banned. Even I was banned for biting the ball – something I'd done out of sheer desperation. I'm sorry for it and will always regret it. I did it so that we could win. I was wrong.

But I need to talk more about what was happening beyond stupid mistakes. This was a time for reckoning. I was going to become captain.

Honestly, it's all about *niyat*, intentions. I am crystal clear about leadership starting with good *niyat*. Without it, no help comes your way from God, or from others. One must have a clear and clean *niyat* for everyone. It's an approach I reserve even for adversaries, like Yousuf – despite our differences, I wanted him in my squad. In the same manner, I put behind bad memories with some other guys too. I gave opportunities to the younger members of the team. Some of them took advantage of it and did well. Some did not and to this day they are struggling.

I spent a lot of time building confidence amongst the younger guys. It was important for me to know what they were thinking, what their fears were, how they wanted to approach our game. Sometimes I broke protocol and took them out shopping, eating and even partying. I was in no mood to lose a game on the field, or my team's confidence in me. I didn't want to give up my captaincy for the sake of protocol and decorum. There was no obligation to maintain a certain distance with me. I wanted them to tell me what was on their mind, if they wanted to bat at another position, if they were in trouble with the PCB or the management.

As captain, my first tour was to Sri Lanka for the 2010 Asia Cup. I hit two centuries and was Player of the Tournament. The team lost, but people started noticing something – that I had brought back the team's fighting spirit; that I was a different man as captain; that I was bringing the team back on the world stage as a match-winning side.

I took risks too. I promoted myself up the order. I took my game by the horns. I decided to step up as a batsman. As captain, I had a point to prove in the Asia Cup.

We almost clinched the first match against India. I got a 32 from 25, but our finest bowling attack in a decade – Shoaib Akhtar, Abdul Razzaq, Mohammad Amir, Saeed Ajmal, Shoaib Malik and I – let the game slip on the second-last ball, letting Harbhajan Singh smash Amir for a six over mid-wicket.

I tried to redeem us in the match against Sri Lanka, coming in at 32/4 while chasing 242, and smashing 109 from 76. Muralitharan paid dearly that day, conceding 71 in his 10 overs, most of